irregular pattern and is called dense regular and dense irregular tissues. **Dense regular connective tissues** primarily contain collagen fibres in rows between many parallel bundles of tissues and a few elastic fibres. The major cell type is **fibroblast.** It attaches muscles and bones and withstands great tensile stress when pulling force is applied in one direction. This connective tissue is present in **tendons,** that attach skeletal muscles to bones and ligaments attach one bone to another. **Dense irregular connective tissues** have bundles of thick collagen fibres and fibroblasts which are arranged irregularly. The major cell type is the **fibroblast**. It is able to withstand tension exerted in many directions and provides structural strength. Some elastic fibres are also present. It is found in the skin as the leathery dermis and forms fibrous capsules of organs such as kidneys, bones, cartilages, muscles, nerves and joints.

Elastic connective tissue contains high proportion of elastic fibres. It allows recoil of tissues following stretching. It maintains the pulsatile flow of blood through the arteries and the passive recoil of lungs following inspiration. It is found in the walls of large arteries; ligaments associated with **vertebral column** and within the walls of the **bronchial tubes.**

Specialised connective tissues are classified as cartilage, bones and blood. The intercellular material of **cartilage** is solid and pliable and resists compression. Cells of this tissue (chondrocytes) are enclosed in small cavities within the matrix secreted by them (Figure 3.6). Most of the cartilages in vertebrate embryos are replaced by bones in adults. Cartilage is present in the tip of nose, outer ear joints, ear pinna, between adjacent bones of the vertebral column, limbs and hands in adults.

Bones have a hard and non-pliable ground substance rich in calcium salts and collagen fibres which gives strength to the bones. It is the main tissue that provides structural frame to the body. Bones support and protect softer tissues and organs. The bone cells (osteocytes) are present in the spaces called **lacunae**. Limb bones, such as the long bones of the legs, serve weight-bearing functions. They also interact with skeletal muscles attached to them to bring about movements. The bone marrow in some bones is the site of production of blood cells.

Blood is the fluid connective tissue containing plasma, red blood cells (RBC), white blood cells (WBC) and platelets. It functions as the transport medium for the cardiovascular system, carrying nutrients, wastes, respiratory gases throughout the body. You will learn more about blood in Chapter 7.

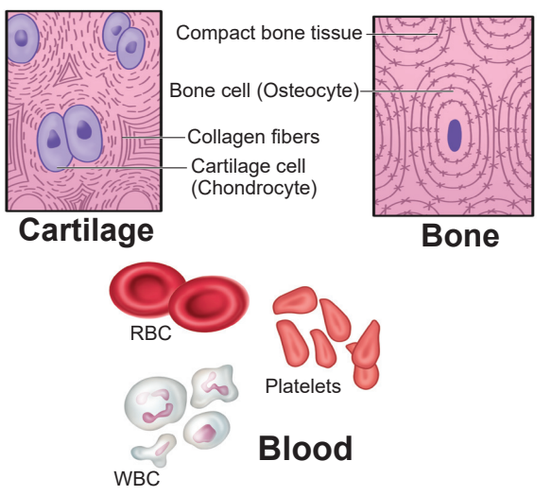


Figure 3.6 Specialized connective tissues

You are looking at a slide of a tissue through the compound microscope and you see striped branching cells that connect with one another. What type of muscle are you viewing?

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